THE CATASTROPHE IN NUMBERS

The mortality rate stands at 4.5 per cent of the infected cattle in the desert state

14 MILLION
CATTLE POPULATION

1.3 MILLION
INFECTED

1.25 MILLION
TREATED

59,027
DEATH TOLL

772,868
RECOVERED

1.08 MILLION
VACCINATED

**Figures as on Sept. 18*



IMPACT ON ECONOMY

80%
Of rural households in Rajasthan keep livestock

10%
The contribution of animal husbandry sector in state's GDP

₹500 CRORE
Estimated losses to the state's rural economy this year

Source: Animal husbandry department, Rajasthan

a hundred kilometres from Jaipur, at Dhaka Ki Dhani village in Sikar district, Om Prakash has lost three cows to LSD, leaving him with just five bovines. As he applies burnt engine oil on the wounds of a calf (it apparently repels insects and facilitates healing), the small-time dairy farmer hopes his remaining livestock survives the outbreak. His daily income has dropped by Rs 1,200 per day with the daily milk production dwindling from 50 litres to 20 litres within just over a week. To add to his woes, he had to spend Rs 1,000 on each of his cows' burial.

Bigger dairies are feeling the pinch too. In Bikaner, Babu Lal, managing director of the Urmul Dairy, was expecting to raise its daily milk collection from 70,000 litres to 100,000 litres. Instead, it has fallen to 55,000 litres. "Even as cows with better immunity have survived, their milk yield has fallen drastically," says Babu Lal. Officials in the animal husbandry department say that the infected milch animals may take up to a year before they can contribute to a normal yield. An official expects losses to be to the tune of Rs 500 crore this year, adding that the figures could rise further if the outbreak isn't controlled soon.

MULTIPLE THREATS

Rajasthan continues to report a bulk of the cow fatalities due to LSD in India, though the state officials allege underreporting by other states. Kataria attributes the high incidence of LSD to a large cattle population in Rajasthan, and the extended rainy season that led to rampant breeding of mosquitoes and flies, carriers of the virus. The freely wandering stray cattle are further increasing the risk of spread. At a cow shelter run by the Fatehpur Panjrapole Society in Sikar, two veterinarians have been deputed to treat infected cows brought in ambulances from the nearby areas. Yet, 105 have died.

P.C. Kishan, commissioner, animal husbandry, says the daily mortality due to LSD was as high as 4,000 in Rajasthan in the initial days of the outbreak. Currently, it has come down to about 1,000, but with the LSD virus mutating over time, the fears of another surge—even in areas such as the westernmost district of Jaisalmer, which has not reported any death for three weeks—looms large. "So far, six mutations of the virus have been detected in the state," says Kishan.

Besides vectors, stray animals and virus mutations, the disposal of carcasses has emerged as a major challenge. At Santrela, where the panchayat has identified an open space to bury carcasses brought from half a dozen neighbouring villages, all caution has been thrown to the wind. About 15-20 carcasses are dumped in a large pit over several hours before being buried. Ideally, each carcass should be covered with salt and soil immediately, to keep flies and mosquitoes away. Villagers say it is not practical, given the high fatality rate in rural areas. Even in towns, where contractors are supposed to safely dispose of the carcasses in dumping grounds, these are being thrown in the open, adding to the risk of virus spread.

Given the way the virus has spread, leading to high mortality among cows, necessitating their mass vaccination and 'social distancing', comparisons are being drawn with the coronavirus. Hameed, a bullock-cart driver who works on the outskirts of Bikaner, is convinced: "Lumpy is like Covid-19. Nothing works on it, and it spreads unabated. But, unlike the coronavirus, which hit the urban areas hard, this disease is ruining our villages."

The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) has accused the Ashok Gehlot-led Congress government in Rajasthan of failing to prevent the spread, unlike most other states, despite early detection and warning. The chief minister, on his part, has written to the Centre, urging it to declare LSD a "national calamity". The state government has also released Rs 30 crore to fund the ongoing efforts to control the outbreak while all MLAs have contributed Rs 10 lakh each from their discretionary funds. This, clearly, is not enough. ■